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THE NEW WORLD DISORDER

America's withdrawal from the existing world order means it will be each one for themselves, with power and force now setting the rules. India must self-strengthen and build a peaceful periphery

IN barely two months, President Donald Trump has made evident the phase transformation that is underway in global geopolitics. We are witnessing the end of the US-led world order, the demise of the West as a unified geopolitical force and the diminished agency of the liberal globalisers who determined US foreign policy for extended periods.

To be sure, the protectionism, isolationism and nativism bordering on racism that we now see in the US is not new. President Trump's adoption of these policies is a result of long-building historical trends. This means that they are likely to be long-lasting and that there is no going back to earlier times. The manner of their implementation is, of course, uniquely his own. For many years to come, the US and Europe will be preoccupied with their internal reordering and regional security issues.

The effects of this shift on the world and India are many and consequential. Though put on hold for three months, Trump's tariffs and abandonment of international norms, commitments and institutions amount to America turning away from the world. The legitimacy of US power and influence and her reputation as a reliable ally or partner have diminished considerably.

India will face a much harsher international environment in which to pursue our primary interest, namely, the transformation of the nation. Can globalisation, of which India was the second greatest beneficiary after China, continue in the rest of the world without the USA? This seems doubtful; the idea is a product of nostalgia for times past that are unlikely to return. More likely is a descent into protectionism in the world economy and a focus on regional trading blocs, with commodity exporters in the Global South suffering the most as the global economy slows. As the only major economy that is not a member of any regional trading bloc, this would affect India seriously.

Trump could well make China great again. China is already the economic hub of Asia and much of the developing world. The US administration's tariff and other actions reinforce China's pivotal role in the world economy. If the US is closed to China, we can expect a flood of Chinese industrial investment and exports to the rest of the world, including India. If the US under Trump persists with its high tariffs and other economic steps against China, the Chinese economy will pay a price, for it depends on the world for 25 per cent of what it eats, for its oil and gas energy, for commodities and access to markets which keep her economy going, and for technologies. Exports still account for about 15 per cent of China's GDP. Equally, the temptation for a US-China deal remains strong for a Trump who is unlikely to defend Taiwan, and for his billionaire supporters whose fortunes depend on China. The US-China equation is the great known unknown in today's calculus.

What about geopolitics? The Trump administration's disdain for Europe and treatment of allies like Ukraine means that America's friends in Europe, Southeast Asia and Northeast Asia will look to alternatives to their